

TIMELINE

- **January 19, 1807** Born in Westmoreland County, Virginia, son of Major General Henry Lee, governor of Virginia. He is one of six children.
- **1829** Graduating second in his class from West Point, Lee chooses to serve in the Corps of Engineers.
- **June 30, 1831** Marries his cousin Mary Custis, daughter of the step-grandson of George Washington; the couple lives at the Custis mansion, Arlington House.
- **1847-48** In the War with Mexico, Lee serves on the staff of General Winfield Scott, distinguishing himself at Cerro Gordo and Churubusco.
- **1852** Appointed superintendent of West Point.
- **1855** Transfers to the cavalry, serving as a lieutenant colonel on the western frontier.
- **1857** His wife inherits 189 enslaved people, boosting his worth as a propertied aristocrat. He later petitions the Virginia legislature to permit him to keep them longer than his father-in-law's will stipulates, a request that is denied.
- **October 1859** On home leave, Lee commands the successful assault on John Brown's abolitionists at the U.S. Arsenal at Harpers Ferry.
- **March 1861** Promoted to colonel with command of the U.S. First Cavalry.
- **April 1861** As the Civil War breaks out, Lee rejects an invitation to command Union forces; he resigns to offer his services to Virginia.
- **May 1861** Federal troops occupy Arlington House; Lee is appointed a brigadier general in the Confederate Army.